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ARTICLE

The Church's Surrender To The Culture Of Death - Special Liturgy For Euthanasia





BY PNW STAFF JULY 01, 2026

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For centuries, the Church has stood at the bedside of the dying with a simple but profound mission: to comfort the suffering, proclaim the hope of Christ, and remind both the living and the dying that life belongs ultimately to God. That sacred calling is now being dramatically redefined in Canada.

The Anglican Church of Canada has authorized the trial use of a 66-page liturgy specifically designed for those choosing Medical Assistance in Dying (MAiD), complete with prayers before the lethal drugs are administered, prayers afterward, confession, anointing with oil, Holy Communion, blessings, and other rites traditionally reserved for preparing believers to meet God.

It is difficult to overstate the significance of this decision.

This is not merely the Church ministering to someone who has already decided to end his or her life. It is the Church creating an official religious framework surrounding the act itself. Whether intended or not, the message received by many believers will be unmistakable: euthanasia is compatible with faithful Christian discipleship.

That represents a profound theological shift.

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The Anglican Synod attempts to avoid taking a direct moral position by emphasizing the Church's responsibility to provide pastoral care regardless of the circumstances. Compassion is certainly central to Christianity. Jesus ministered to the sick, the brokenhearted, and the dying. Christians should never abandon those facing unbearable suffering.

But biblical compassion has never meant affirming every decision someone makes.

Throughout Scripture, shepherds are repeatedly commanded not only to comfort God's people but also to teach, correct, warn, and guide them in truth. Pastoral care separated from moral truth ceases to be biblical shepherding and is little more than emotional accompaniment.

The document itself illustrates this tension.

It speaks movingly about people enduring terrible illnesses, exhausted by pain, longing for rest, and wishing not to burden their families. Few Christians would fail to sympathize with those heartbreaking realities. Yet nowhere does suffering itself become justification for intentionally ending innocent human life.

Instead, Scripture consistently presents suffering as one of the painful consequences of living in a fallen world while simultaneously affirming that human life remains sacred from conception until natural death.

King David declared, "My times are in Your hands" (Psalm 31:15).

Job, after losing everything, confessed, "The Lord gave, and the Lord has taken away."

God Himself tells Israel in Deuteronomy, "I put to death and I bring to life."

The consistent biblical witness is clear: God alone possesses ultimate authority over life and death.

This is precisely why historic Christianity--whether Roman Catholic, Orthodox, or Protestant--has overwhelmingly opposed both suicide and euthanasia for nearly two thousand years.

The concern is not merely about death itself.

It is about sovereignty.



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Who ultimately determines when a human life ends?

When physicians intentionally administer lethal drugs, and the Church surrounds that act with sacramental language and sacred ritual, it inevitably communicates that the act itself has moral legitimacy.

The Anglican liturgy repeatedly refers to God's presence during the euthanasia procedure. One suggested prayer speaks of the room becoming "a thin-space that is sacred." Afterwards, another prayer thanks God for helping those present offer their loved one "their final gift" and seeing them "safely home."

These are extraordinarily powerful theological statements.

Language shapes belief.

Liturgy shapes doctrine.



For generations, Christians have understood this principle. What churches repeatedly pray eventually becomes what congregations believe.

That is why this decision extends far beyond denominational politics.

Canada already has one of the world's most expansive euthanasia programs. Since MAiD was legalized in 2016, eligibility has expanded dramatically--from terminal illness to chronic conditions, and from those whose deaths were reasonably foreseeable to many whose deaths are not. Debate continues over future expansion involving mental illness and other categories.

Many Christians have watched those developments with growing concern, asking where the cultural boundaries ultimately end.

Now, rather than serving as a prophetic voice questioning that trajectory, one of Canada's historic churches appears to be adapting to it.

History repeatedly demonstrates that when the Church stops challenging culture, it soon begins reflecting it.

The earliest Christians gained respect in the Roman Empire precisely because they refused to adopt Rome's practices surrounding unwanted infants, suicide, and the value of vulnerable human life. They became known as people who rescued the abandoned, cared for plague victims, and defended life when doing so was costly.

Their witness was not built upon cultural accommodation.

It was built upon holy distinction.

Today's Church faces a remarkably similar crossroads.

Modern Western culture increasingly defines compassion as affirming personal autonomy above all else. Christianity has historically defined compassion differently: walking faithfully beside those who suffer without surrendering God's definition of truth.

Those are not always the same thing.

Christians absolutely should sit with the dying.

They should pray with them.

They should anoint them.

They should remind them of Christ's promises, encourage reconciliation with loved ones, proclaim forgiveness through the Gospel, and assure them that death itself has been conquered through Jesus Christ.

But there is a profound difference between preparing someone for the natural end of life and preparing someone for an intentionally induced death.

One ministers through suffering.

The other risks sanctifying the act that ends it.

The tragedy of this moment is not merely that another denomination has adopted a controversial position. The greater tragedy is that countless confused believers may now conclude that because the Church has created prayers for euthanasia, God must surely approve of it as well.

That is precisely why the Church exists--not simply to echo society's changing moral consensus, but to proclaim God's unchanging truth with both conviction and compassion.

When the Church ceases calling sin what Scripture calls sin, it may temporarily gain cultural approval.

But it inevitably loses its prophetic voice.

And when the Church begins blessing what God has never blessed, it is not merely changing its liturgy.



It is changing its witness.

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